

Samsung Galaxy S26 Ultra

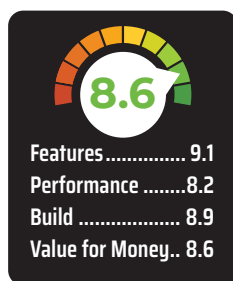
King of the hill

I've been living with the Samsung Galaxy S26 Ultra for a while now, and the 'new phone' smell has officially worn off. After my first 48 hours with the device, I was mostly charmed by the ergonomics and the slick Cobalt Violet finish of my review unit. But a premium flagship phone, especially the kind that starts at Rs 1.4 lakh, isn't defined by a weekend, but by the small wins and the annoyances that crop up over time in daily usage.

I've used the Galaxy S26 Ultra as my daily driver for work and play, and I've genuinely put it through the wringer to see if it actually deserves that 'Ultra' tag.

RISKING IT ALL FOR THE COBALT VIOLET FINISH

I'll start with this: I haven't put a case on this phone. In fact, I am a believer in using phones without cases, always. I know, it sounds like a recipe for a heart attack. I remember dropping my Galaxy S23 Ultra on a concrete floor, only to turn it over and find that the back glass had cracked from the side. But despite that incident, even after the phone was repaired, I used it without a case. My point is, when I've spent a good amount of money on a thing of beauty, I want to flaunt it. And it isn't just about flaunting the looks; the Galaxy S26 Ultra has these subtle, rounded edges that make the 6.9-inch frame actually manageable. As I noted in my initial impressions, the phone doesn't dig into my palm when I'm scrolling through Instagram past midnight.



The Cobalt Violet finish is a masterstroke. Honestly, I wasn't too impressed with it when I saw it in the leaks. But, after using the device for the past few weeks, the finish has certainly grown on me. It's got this deep, metallic lustre that looks professional and industrial without being boring. Again, I believe the white one is the best finish and I have seen it in person; it looks stunning. But the violet has a classy vibe that has grown on me.

However, there is a catch. Because it's so slim and the camera island is so pronounced, the phone wobbles if you try to use it while it's lying on a desk. It's a bit of a design trade-off. I've personally adapted by just... not using it on a table.

THE PRIVACY DISPLAY

The headline feature of the Galaxy S26 Ultra this year is the Privacy Display,

and I'm just going to say it: I can't go back to a normal phone screen now. Did Samsung just slap a software filter to achieve this? No, it's a hardware-level implementation that controls light dispersion at the pixel level.

How do I use it? I've set it to trigger automatically for WhatsApp, Instagram, and my gallery. Since I am always surrounded by someone or the other, at work and in public spaces, the 'zero peeking' tech kicks in effortlessly. So, if someone is standing right next to me, they see a dark screen, while I can see my chats or photos clearly. And, if I need maximum protection, I simply enable the 'Maximum privacy protection' toggle for the full throttle mode, and it becomes virtually impossible for anyone to see what I'm doing from the sides. Now, that's what you call innovation.

Now, in doing so, does the display take a hit? Yes. Are the viewing angles as wide as they used to be? Nope. And there's also a slight drop in brightness when the privacy mode is active. But honestly, who uses their phone from an angle, like sideways? So, when you're looking at it head-on, and that's how a phone is supposed to be looked at, it's still the best 10-bit panel in the game: vibrant, sharp, and gorgeous. For me, the trade-off for actual privacy is a price I'm more than willing to pay.

ONE UI 8.5 AND THE AI GOODNESS

One UI 8.5 is, in my opinion, the most mature Android skin out there. Because it's not just about the big features, but it's also about the aesthetics and the 'feel' of the OS. The animations and transitions in One UI 8.5 are buttery fluid, and little touches like being able to deeply customise the control centre or having a time zone converter in the clock app are some of the small attention to detail that make a big difference.